

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

Rwanda School Project_Rwanda_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

Rwanda School Project (RSP)

Fellowship City

Rwamagana

Fellowship Country

Rwanda

Fellowship Start Date

08/28/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/29/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Princeton in Africa Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Designing and teaching Environmental Studies curriculum
- Started Read Time book groups, organizing the group selection and evaluation systems and onboarding the staff
- Collaborating with English and STEM teachers to co-teach classes
- Coordinating Environmental Club educational tours across Rwanda
- Providing college counseling and application guidance to 40 seniors

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

I had an initial meeting with my supervisor to talk about work expectations.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?
Describe a representative day at work.

I arrive at work at 10:30 am and prepare for a late morning class or Read Time. At 11:30, I teach Environmental Studies or supervise my Read Time groups. I then take a break for lunch, socializing with the rest of the staff, typically playing some cards. After lunch, I edit essays, plan future lessons, and organize Environmental Club trips. Later in the afternoon, I co-teach an information and communication technology class. From 4:30-6:30 pm, I supervise the computer lab for the seniors to work on college applications. I help them understand the application process and advise them on their essays and activities lists. Just after 6:30, I lock the computer lab and leave work.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

So far, I have worked hard with my co-fellow to assist the seniors with college applications to United States schools. Together we have developed a Google Classroom with many great resources for the students and led several information sessions on topics from application timelines to essay writing. We successfully assisted six early application students to apply to eight institutions. We are currently working with another ten students on their regular decision applications.

Additionally, I have been working on organizing Environmental Club trips for the students to learn about different sustainability initiatives happening throughout Rwanda. We took our first trip on Saturday, November 12th, to visit two organic coffee cooperatives in Gakenke District, three hours away from the school. Transport limitations only allowed for 26 students to attend, so I organized an essay-based selection process, where students applied to go on the trip. I worked with school staff to select the candidates. I coordinated with the directors of both cooperatives to develop itineraries for our visit and supervised the trip, lasting around 15 hours. I have also organized an initial partnership meeting with the Rwandan Chapter of the Global Youth Biodiversity Network. This meeting will take place this coming Wednesday, November 30th. Organization representatives will meet with school staff to plan future partnerships and then present to the students the importance of biodiversity and the organization's work.

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I work at a school with around 230 students and over 40 staff members, including teachers, administrators, guards, cooks, and boarding staff. I do the majority of my work in the main administration building, in a communal work space shared by the rest of the teachers. I also share a small private office within the admin building with my co-fellow, utilizing it for private meetings, storage, and a quiet work space.

To whom do you report?

I report to the school director.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

Continue organizing Environmental Club trips, giving every student a chance to attend one trip this year and forming relationships with different Rwandan organizations that can sustain future educational opportunities

Developing professional panels to give students opportunities to learn from different Rwandan professionals and expose them to a wide variety of career / vocational possibilities

Organize a system that can prepare younger students for college applications and support them with those applications in the future, including expanding the Google Classroom resources and general access to computers

Continuing to work with the English and Information and Communication Technology teachers to develop exercises supporting typing, writing, and computer skills

Getting involved with student extracurricular groups, like the girls empowerment group, ICT club, and possibly developing groups geared towards English speaking practice

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?

Please provide more information on your response above.

I had an initial meeting with my supervisor at the beginning of my fellowship where he encouraged me to develop my personal professional goals, going off of the guiding job description. Since, I have had informal check-ins with him on topic specific work. I plan to have another general check-in at the start of the next term after the holidays.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Irregularly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I organized a school field trip to visit two coffee cooperatives in Gakenke District.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I feel comfortable with all of the tasks I have taken on so far. I appreciate the flexibility I have been given to pursue my interests and work at my own pace. In this work environment, I feel like I have been able to accomplish a lot.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my ticket from the Ethiopian Airlines website. I flew on Air Canada from Minneapolis to Toronto and Ethiopian Airlines from Toronto to Addis Ababa, Addis Ababa to Kigali. The one way ticket cost \$951.62.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

H2

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Supervisor applied online for me

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

After arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$50 entry fee and \$150 visa

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

The costs were covered by the sponsor organization, Labouisse.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

No suggestions

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I already had my yellow fever vaccination, otherwise I believe it would be required. No other vaccinations were required, but I got the Typhoid series and preventative rabies as recommended. I got my insurance to cover both vaccinations, so I only paid a minor co-pay. I also bought malaria pills.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My arrival was easy. I can suggest no improvements.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided and paid for by my host organization, using funds from the post sponsor organization Labouisse.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Rural

Please describe your living environment

I live in a small neighborhood, among other houses and small businesses, and near farm fields.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

It is a ten minute walk from my house to my work. I pay nothing for transportation to work.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

The area I live in is pretty rural. There are small shops nearby and a large open air market about a 20 minute walk from my house. However, the closest major grocery stores, general shopping, and an airport are in Kigali, a 1-2 hour drive away.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather is fairly consistent, with temperatures from 60 to 85 degrees Fahrenheit most days. It is currently the rainy season, so it rains a majority of the days for at least a couple hours. The rain can come suddenly and be very torrential.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Appropriate clothing would be anything that is comfortable for the sometimes hot temperature that doesn't reveal too much. The employee handbook said to not show shoulders and thighs. That being said, I have definitely seen other women employees showing their shoulders with wide strap tank shirts or dresses. I have never heard anyone comment on that. Knee length or longer skirts and dresses are nice for women. Normal professional clothes are also fine depending on comfort and the temperature. Some people dress really nice, while others opt for casual-professional. Nice sandals are nice, and people really pay attention to shoes. There are also a lot of beautiful sandals you can buy here. A raincoat is a must and maybe a pair of waterproof shoes for when it's rainy.

How have you been spending your free time?

I have spent most of my free time just hanging out at home or going on walks/errands around town. I have gone to explore Kigali a few times with my co-fellow. We were once invited to a Basketball All-Star game followed by a concert in Kigali, which was a blast. We also took a trip to see the Mountain Gorillas in Musanze District. I have visited the new wetland park in Kigali Nyandungu twice and love it. Here in Rwamagana, we haven't found too much to do. There is a pretty garden called Harmony Gardens with some beautiful flowers. We like to go to Dereva Hotel restaurant on occasion for some nice dining. There is also one new coffee shop that is cute. We have thrown a few parties at our house and invited co-workers. Not many people here have invited me anywhere, but most of the teachers are either men living alone (their families live in another part of the country) or people with young families.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I have been able to stay in touch with my loved ones back home. I thank this ability to the internet I pay for at my house, which is really good quality. I am in a long-distance relationship, and the ability to talk most days has been wonderful. Given the time difference between here and the state (currently 7 hours from Eastern Time after daylight savings), most people aren't available to talk until late. This is another reason that I am so grateful for my flexible work schedule as it allows me to stay up later to connect with my loved ones and start my work days later.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I feel safe at my work and residence. I have not experienced any crime, nor heard about much crime occurring. The one exception being last week I attended a friend's birthday dinner at the Dereva Hotel restaurant, about a 20 minute walk from my house. We finished the dinner after 11pm and wanted to get a bike back, but there were no bikes out on the road. I was with three young adult Rwandan women, and they were very uncomfortable to have been caught out without transport that late. One of them mentioned that a child had been killed near the school recently, which was the first and only time I was informed of crime occurring in the area. Eventually, the birthday girl's dad came to pick us up and dropped me off at home.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

My co-fellow and I live in a gated house. We have a housekeeper that stays at the house during the day and a security guard during the night. We always make sure to lock the front gate and the front door when we leave for the day and at night. We typically don't go out very late (after 9pm), and when we go out after dark, we are usually together. I always keep my phone on me when I go out alone.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have had no experience with crime so far.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Again, I have had no experience with crime so far. I would recommend the current house and security setup that I have.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I am working towards most of my goals. I have made an effort to connect with my coworkers, the students, and other people in my life here. Looking forward I would like to do this with more intentionality, especially working harder to learn more about the people I have weekly interactions with, like local store owners and other school staff that I don't normally interact with. I also want to make a bigger effort to connect with my co-fellows and take advantage of the PiAf resources designed to bring the community together.

I have also worked on learning about the local context, history, politics, and current events, but since my work life has gotten busier, my independent exploration has reduced. I would like to reinvigorate my curiosity and ask a lot more questions to the people around me.

Finally, I want to push myself to try new things, whether going to new local restaurants, using a charcoal stove, joining a running group, or even just cooking a crazy recipe.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I have only a few frustrations. With work, sometimes I feel like I am not being communicated to about certain things. For example, the past couple weekends, I have gone to work to help the seniors finish up college applications and there have been events happening that were not communicated to me. Also, there is sometimes unclear responsibility between different staff, especially when it comes to library resources. I have encountered this working on the reading group project, where the library system is not functional, leaving the responsibility of broken or missing books unclear whether it falls on students or read group leaders.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

There is nothing that I have needed that I haven't been able to acquire. My co-fellow and I do desire a sharper knife or knife sharpener for cooking, which we have been looking for, but I am still hopeful we will find what we want here.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I honestly haven't experienced too much culture shock. I attribute this to living with a co-fellow. This has helped me feel very comfortable and secure in my environment, having someone from a familiar background to live life with and reflect with. I would say that the down side to this is I don't feel like I have had the incentive to push my comfort zone as much as I normally would be interested in, trying more new experiences, learning the local language and culture more. This is a goal of mine going forward in my fellowship.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I've been surprised by how comfortable I am in Rwanda. I feel safe 99% of the time here, which is more than I feel in some places in the United States.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The most challenging part of my experience has been dealing with the obstacle of limited computer resources for students and frequent WiFi problems. This makes the challenge of helping students with their typing and computer skills all the more difficult.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

I miss being able to communicate with most people, without a language barrier. I miss easy access to different outdoor recreation like canoeing and hiking on trails (I do most of my running and walking along busy roads). I miss petting my cat or any cats!

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

I appreciate the nice weather. I really like the culture of greeting and checking in on people and how platonic handholding is a normal thing between anyone. I love that most of the foods I buy are local and fresh.

How is your stipend being paid?

My stipend is paid monthly in USD to my US account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No, but I'm asking my family to help contribute to my plane ticket home for the holidays as my Christmas gift.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$5.00	\$0.00	\$35.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$40.00	\$5.00	\$20.00	\$85.00	\$15.00	\$80.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$3.00	\$0.00	\$80.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	268.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Orientation helped prepare me sufficiently on what to pack and how to approach the start of my fellowship. I don't feel well connected to the rest of the fellows because I had to conduct the orientation virtually, so I hope that the mid-year retreat will help with that.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

I think orientation was sufficient for what I have encountered so far on my fellowship (although I have not run into many obstacles).

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

I would appreciate discussing ways to be careful about not approaching our work with a US-centered mind view and ethic. I find it really tricky dealing with students that idolize the United States. I don't want to play into Western-centrism, but at the same time, I want to support their dreams of attending schools that can have a really big impact on their lives.

Also generally, living with another American fellow, I sometimes feel like we can create an echo chamber of our own biases, so I would like to talk about ways to work on expanding perspectives during the fellowship year.